

a strategy to get the magic, ancestors, or deities involved: They set about emulating the foreigners, and recreating their customs and rituals. They did this in various ways.

The islanders recreated the airstrips, marking them with sticks, and illuminating them with torches. They built thatched huts along the runways, outfitting these with bamboo, vines, and tin cans strung on wires to mimic control towers with radio antennae, including a place for a man to sit and wear coconut earphones to communicate with the airplanes. They stood on the landing strips making landing signals to attract the planes. They built airplanes out of sticks, leaves, and grass, in order to attract other airplanes. They made airplane sounds. They replicated complex marching drills and conducted these prescribed dances while holding makeshift firearms.

Everything was perfect. The configuration of the runways was accurate, the airplanes were highly realistic, and the huts were faithful reproductions of control towers. The drills and the marching ceremonies had been flawlessly reproduced. All was as it had been during the prosperous days. Yet, despite their elaborate preparations, the natives still lacked something crucial and fundamental, because, of course, the planes failed to land and the cargo failed to materialize.

It was true that there was a connection between the rituals of the foreigners and the arrival of the cargo. The natives were right about that. The rituals did accompany the arrival of the cargo. And in some sense the rituals were also required as a condition for the arrival of the cargo. But they did not independently cause the arrival of the cargo. This was the flaw in the story. The real reasons the cargo came were much more subtle and complex, and related to hidden factors that were completely removed from the experience of the islanders and their explanations. The true nature of the rituals was misinterpreted by the natives as being causative, when the reality was totally different.^{[2](#)}

And while we might consider the natives naïve, we also need to recognize these natives are only human, and behave just as other humans behave. They created a plausible explanation, essentially out of thin air, and believed it.

Humans believe in stories at the expense of evidence all the time—even in our modern society. And these stories abound. Below we list a sampling of